

carbon neutrality targets. In India, by 2030, EV penetration will be 30 per cent. Conservative industry specialists say it will be 8-10 per cent. That means the remaining portion of the cars will be non-EV and those will be newly manufactured and registered in the Indian market. So, we have to introduce EVs, but we also have to address non-EV cars with some better technology to make them environment friendly. To achieve this, I believe we have to employ all possible technologies which are better for the environment. Of course, we'll do EVs, but we're also trying to take a technology-neutral approach. We don't care which technology we're going to employ as long as it works towards a better environment. That's the most important thing. Secondly, that technology has to be cost-effective. Because at the end of the day, the customer will decide which car to drive, not the government or manufacturers. We want to make sure we're chosen by the customer.

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Why did SMC invest into EVs in Gujarat and MSI didn't?

We will introduce EVs one by one, but the first EV must be produced somewhere either in Gujarat or Haryana. There was a consideration where to produce it. One of the advantages of producing at the Gujarat plant is that it is close to the export port

from India. This EV we'll strongly market in India but at the same time, it's a strategically important model globally for Suzuki, also because this is one of the first EVs it's going to introduce in the global market, and we have to be strong in exports. So, being closer to the port is a big advantage if we have a factory in Gujarat. But if EVs become 50 per cent of the total market tomorrow, then of course every factory of MSI [in India] and Suzuki in Gujarat will start producing EVs, and it will not just be limited to Gujarat.

ogy and expertise. EVs are important for both OEMs but it's still very expensive and infrastructure is still an issue. Although hybrids are also expensive, they're not as expensive as EVs. It doesn't need infrastructure and can be one of the interim solutions until everything is EV or hydrogen or some other technology. Our target is to try to make in India. Localisation is the key for us to bring the costs down for our products, even for hybrids. It's the strength of Maruti Suzuki to localise. It will give us the power to make the technology more cost-effective.

one of the people I deeply admire. I've worked with him at the head office as well as in India. He leads by example.

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What's your leadership style?

Everybody has their own style. My style is not very aggressive or very strong. My style is being a good listener and understanding what people want and what they're thinking. I try to listen to as many people as possible to define which direction we have to move in. I'll call myself a good listener rather than a dictator.

| 41

IN INDIA, WE HAVE 300 MILLION COWS. COW DUNG IS LIKE GOLD HERE. ALSO, AGRICULTURAL WASTE IS THERE. IF WE CAN UTILISE THESE TO MAKE BIOFUEL, IT WILL BE VERY CLOSE TO CARBON NEUTRAL

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Let us talk about your partnership with Toyota. Will it help you get your hybrid portfolio right?

Our collaboration with Toyota is very wide. It's like an iceberg. You can only see one-tenth of it, the rest is under the water. We're very calmly progressing our collaboration with Toyota, and it is proving profitable for our company as well. It's giving us a big opportunity to utilise their technol-

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Would it be difficult to fill Kenichi Ayukawa's shoes?

It would be extremely difficult. He has been here for nine years. He's got huge expertise and by utilising those skills, he managed the company well. I don't have as much expertise and experience. For me, it's a challenge. It's going to be trial and error, without too much room for error. Ayukawa san is

One thing I believe is that one must think about the person receiving [something] from you. If you're writing something, it's important for the reader to understand it. Similarly, in a production line, if you're assembling something, you have to make it easier for the person working next to you. The entire process will then be smoother for everyone. **BT**

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